

# Airport Hacks

Cheat Sheet — From Check-In to Gate in Record Time

## THE PERFECT AIRPORT TIMELINE

**T-48h** Online check-in opens. Choose window seats NOW — they're gone within hours.

**T-24h** Reconfirm flight status. Download boarding pass offline in case Wi-Fi fails.

**T-3h** International minimum. Earlier = calmer. Security lines are unpredictable.

**T-2h** Security done. Go to your gate first, then find food — never the other way.

**T-45m** Final boarding call. Be physically AT the gate, not walking towards it.

**T-20m** Gates close without exception. Airlines will not wait — even 1 minute late.

## SECURITY SPEED HACKS

- ♦ Slip-on shoes only — removes the lace-tying step. Saves 2+ minutes every single trip.
- ♦ Belt, coins and jacket go into your bag BEFORE you join the queue, not at the tray.
- ♦ Laptop in a dedicated top pocket — out in 3 seconds, back in 3 seconds. No digging.
- ♦ Liquids bag at the very top of your backpack — pull it out before reaching the trays.
- ♦ TSA PreCheck or EU fast-track lane: a separate line that's often 5× shorter. Worth it.

## LOUNGE ACCESS WITHOUT BUSINESS CLASS

### Priority Pass

Amex Platinum & Curve Metal include free Priority Pass — 1,400+ lounges worldwid

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## LoungeBuddy App

Buy a day pass from €25–40 for any lounge. Book ahead — walk-ins often full.

## DragonPass

Standalone app for booking individual lounge visits in 100+ countries.

## Card Perks

Check your card's fine print: many credit cards include 2 free lounge visits/yea

## YOUR DELAY RIGHTS (EU261)

### EU261 Compensation

1

EU flight delayed 3h+? You're owed €250–600 per person. Applies to EU airlines worldwide AND any airline flying to/from EU.

### AirHelp App

2

Submit your delay claim for free via AirHelp — they handle everything. You pay only if you win (30% fee).

### Meal Vouchers

3

For delays of 2h+, ask at the gate for meal vouchers immediately. Airlines rarely hand them out unprompted.

### Hotel + Transfer

4

Flight cancelled or delayed overnight? The airline MUST provide free hotel, meals and transport. Ask, don't wait.

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## UPGRADE SECRETS

### Dress Smart

5

Looking presentable raises your upgrade chances 3×. Staff upgrade people they'd be comfortable seating in Business.

### Just Ask

6

"Is there any business class availability today?" — costs you nothing. Works surprisingly often on short-haul.

### Check-In Last

7

On overbooked flights, the last passengers to check in are often bumped up to fill Business Class gaps.

### Bid Upgrade

8

Lufthansa, BA, KLM & others offer upgrade bidding 48h before departure. Start 20% above minimum bid.

## LAYOVER PLAYBOOK

2h

Stay airside. Go to your gate first, confirm it's correct, then eat or shop nearby

4h

Use a lounge — nap, shower, real food. Lounge access pays for itself vs. airport p

6h+

Consider a visa-free city visit. Dubai, Istanbul, Singapore all allow this with no

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**Overnight** Book a capsule hotel or lounge sleep pod in advance. Airport floors are noisy and

## QUICK REFERENCE

- |                           |                     |                              |
|---------------------------|---------------------|------------------------------|
| ✓ Boarding pass (offline) | ✓ Charger + adapter | ✓ Water (buy after security) |
| ✓ Snacks                  | ✓ Neck pillow       | ✓ Eye mask + earplugs        |